

Click, Pick And Choose

Six entrepreneurs cash in on a novel idea: renting out books from an online store—and taking care of the troublesome details

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It is the age of the mouse potato. Yet, it is also an age when people like the feel and experience of physical books—even with e-books all over the Internet.

Those who watch a lot of movies would appreciate the fact that the renting out DVDs for an unlimited period of time is a good idea. It is indicative of a good business model: ultimately, no-one watches a DVD more than, say, twice or thrice, but the idea that you aren't time-bound plays a psychological role. It means freedom.

Although we're not focusing here on DVDs, we must mention the success of Netflix.com, launched in 1999 in the United States. The idea was novel—one of those “Why didn't we think of it before?” moments for those who hadn't thought of it before. Think about it: being online, doing a bit of browsing, clicking something, and having a DVD delivered to your doorstep—then keeping as long as you'd like, and dropping it in the mail when you're done watching it. That's a business idea at its best, one that spawns similar ideas. In fact, we have Netflix clones in India—Seventymm.com, Catchflix.com, and others. All sites claim—and seem—to have reasonably large collections, though not yet quite in the league of Netflix.

Now, books being more of an old-world commodity than DVDs, it might seem odd that someone thought up the idea of renting out books à la Netflix—BookSwim.com in the US, August of 2007.

Coming to this part of the world, where we don't have too many public libraries or local circulating libraries, where the majority

hasn't been introduced to the idea of e-book reading yet, but where more and more people are getting online, how does the idea of an online book rental store sound?

Conception

Nine years after having studied together, six friends, now in diverse fields, met to discuss a business venture. Avid readers all six of them, the venture, naturally, was to focus on books.

Possibly inspired by Netflix, possibly by BookSwim, we don't know—Hiten Dedhiya, Hiten Turakhia, Dhairyasheel Pawar, Shibanarayan Rath, Amit Gala, and Kunal Gala discussed, in October 2006, the possibility of renting books online. It was Dedhiya's idea; they decided on a *desi*-sounding name, one that carried the “friendly neighbourhood” motif. Thus was born Librarywala.com.

Creation

This a Web site where you can create a list of books from an online catalogue, then order them—and Librarywala will deliver them to your doorstep free of cost. The site started off in August 2007; their area of operation is limited to Mumbai as of now, and the collection stands at 8,500 books from most popular genres.

In Amazon-like fashion, details such as a brief description of every book, author, publisher, number of pages, and more are listed, along with a photograph of the cover. Payment can be made by cash or cheque pick-up, or by credit / debit card.

If a book one selects is available, the Librarywala team guarantees to deliver it to any address in Mumbai within 24 hours. Even if the books are not available, the team promises to procure them in 21 days.

Foundation

In their college days, the six friends struggled to procure books to feed their reading habit. That, in fact, was the motivation, the driver.

Hiten Dedhiya, a management consultant with five years of experience in strategy design, logistics, operations restructuring, and private equity conceived the actual idea of Librarywala. Dedhiya recollects his past: “The six of us would contribute, buy books, and circulate them amongst ourselves. I therefore thought of pursuing a venture such that today's generation doesn't miss out on books like we had to.”

He discussed his idea with Hiten Turakhia, a software professional managing his own IT solutions company. They then decided to share the idea with the four other friends.

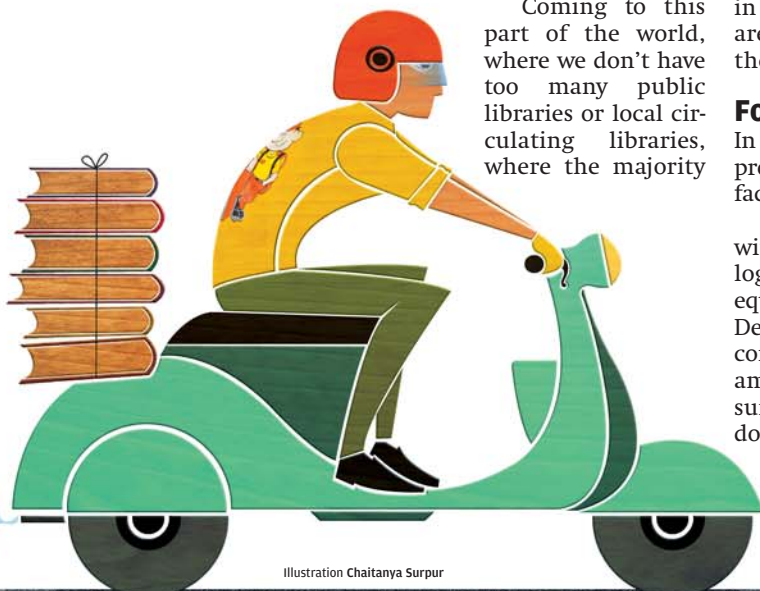


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